Halloween

Trick-or-treating in the USA



Photo: LostplanetKD73, CC BY-SA 4.0

Warm-up

Warm-up

What do you know about Halloween and trick-or-treating?

Go around the room: everyone says one thing.



Photo: U.S. Air Force

A Brief History

Ancient Greece

- The writer **Athenaeus of Naucratis** (lived around AD 200) describes a custom on the island of Rhodes
- Children dressed up as swallows
- They went door to door singing a song and asking for food



Swallows in a Greek wall painting from Akrotiri. Photo: Zde, CC BY-SA 4.0

No food? Mischief!

- If the owner of a house gave them nothing, the children threatened mischief
- The song even threatens to carry off the front door!
- Does this sound familiar?



Swallows in a Greek wall painting from Akrotiri. Photo: Zde, CC BY-SA 4.0

16th-century Scotland: guising

- In Scotland, Halloween was the time for guising
- **Etymology:** what do you think this word means?



Halloween guisers in Shetland, Scotland. Photo: Mike Pennington, CC BY-SA 2.0

16th-century Scotland: guising

- In Scotland, Halloween was the time for guising
- **Etymology:** what do you think this word means?
- From *guise* = appearance, as in *disguise*
- Same Germanic root as German *Weise* (*Art und Weise*)



Halloween guisers in Shetland, Scotland. Photo: Mike Pennington, CC BY-SA 2.0

What is guising?

- Children go door to door in disguise
- They perform a song, a poem or a joke
- In return they get gifts: apples, nuts, sweets or coins
- The first “jack-o’-lanterns” were carved turnips, not pumpkins



A traditional Scottish turnip lantern (“tumshie”). Photo: LornaMCampbell, CC BY-SA 4.0

The roots: Samhain

- Guising goes back to the Celtic festival of *Samhain* (October 31–November 1), the start of winter
- People believed the spirits of the dead came into the human world
- They dressed up as spirits for protection, and received gifts in their name



A Samhain bonfire in Ireland. Photo: EWilson, CC BY-SA 4.0

Guising comes to North America



Before Halloween: Ragamuffin Day

- From 1870 to the 1930s, begging from strangers happened on Thanksgiving, not Halloween
- In New York City, children dressed up as beggars: *Ragamuffin Day*



"Thanksgiving maskers" in New York, 1910s. Photos: Bain News Service, Library of Congress

Trick-or-treating takes off

- In the 1920s and 30s, trick-or-treating became more and more popular
- Halloween parties for children spread too



Children at a Halloween party, Los Angeles, 1935. Photo: Los Angeles Times, CC BY 4.0

A pause for World War II

- From 1942 to 1947, sugar was rationed: no sugar, no candy
- Trick-or-treating paused
- After the war it came back bigger than ever, helped by radio shows, comics like *Peanuts*, and Disney cartoons



Food rationing in the US during World War II. Photo: U.S. Office of War Information

What Do We Actually Do?

Halloween in numbers

74%

of Americans celebrate Halloween

61%

hand out candy

$13.5B

total spending, a new record ($4.1 billion just on candy)

Source: National Retail Federation, Halloween survey (September 2026).

A caveat: New York is different





Left: an apartment building on the Upper West Side (King of Hearts, CC BY-SA 4.0). Right: the Village Halloween Parade, Manhattan (Tzim78, CC BY 4.0)

Myth vs. fact

Which of these traditions do we actually do on Halloween?

Guess: myth or fact?

Myth or fact?

1. Wear costumes



Photo: Don Scarborough, CC BY-SA 2.5

Myth or fact?

1. Wear costumes

FACT

Almost every child dresses up.



Photo: Don Scarborough, CC BY-SA 2.5

Myth or fact?

2. Go to many different buildings

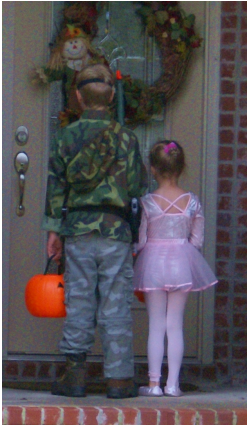


Photo: Belinda Hankins Miller, CC BY 2.0

Myth or fact?

2. Go to many different buildings

MYTH

In New York you stay in your own building and go from apartment to apartment.

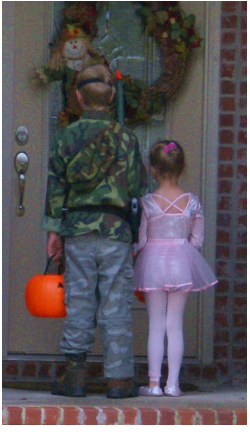


Photo: Belinda Hankins Miller, CC BY 2.0

Myth or fact?

3. Say the full rhyme: “Trick or treat, smell my feet, give me something good to eat!”



Photo: Sarah777, public domain

Myth or fact?

3. Say the full rhyme: “Trick or treat, smell my feet, give me something good to eat!”

MYTH

We just say “Trick or treat!”



Photo: Sarah777, public domain

Myth or fact?

4. TP (toilet paper) people's houses



Photo: Jackie from Monmouth County, NJ, CC BY 2.0

Myth or fact?

4. TP (toilet paper) people's houses

MYTH

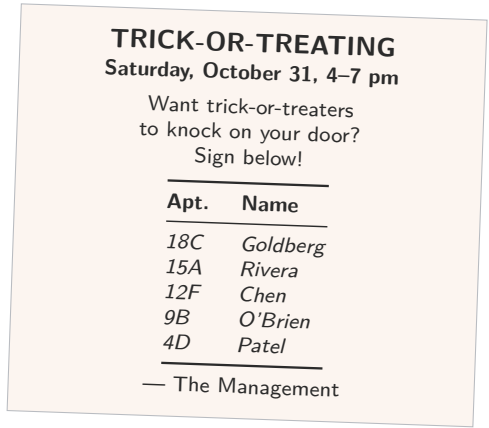
Mostly a teenage prank, and rare.



Photo: Jackie from Monmouth County, NJ, CC BY 2.0

Goal: as much candy as possible

- Many buildings post a sign-up sheet in the lobby
- Neighbors who want trick-or-treaters write down their apartment
- Start at the top of the building and work your way down



TRICK-OR-TREATING

Saturday, October 31, 4–7 pm

Want trick-or-treaters to knock on your door? Sign below!

Apt.	Name
18C	*Goldberg*
15A	*Rivera*
12F	*Chen*
9B	*O'Brien*
4D	*Patel*

— The Management

A recreation of a typical lobby sign-up sheet

Pro tips

- The biggest buildings (high-rises) are usually the best: more apartments, more candy
- Shops on the street also give out candy
- Forget the little bucket: bring a large pillowcase



Photo: King of Hearts, CC BY-SA 4.0

Pumpkin carving

- Before Halloween, families carve pumpkins into jack-o'-lanterns
- A candle goes inside
- Remember: in Scotland and Ireland they used turnips!



Photo: Bobjgalindo, CC BY 4.0

After trick-or-treating

- Empty the pillowcase onto the floor

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- Trade candy with siblings and friends

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- Empty the pillowcase onto the floor
- Trade candy with siblings and friends
- Eat the candy

After trick-or-treating

- Empty the pillowcase onto the floor
- Trade candy with siblings and friends
- Eat the candy
- Feel sick

Things we don't do: tricks

- Nobody does the "trick" part of trick-or-treat
- If a house has no candy, you just go to the next one



Photo: Jackie from Monmouth County, NJ, CC BY 2.0

Things we don't do: go building to building

- In New York you usually stay inside your own building
- The exception: brownstone neighborhoods in Brooklyn, where people decorate their stoops and kids go house to house
- See what that looks like



Brownstones in Park Slope, Brooklyn. Photo: Danny Lyon, public domain

Things we don't do: elaborate costumes

- Most people buy a simple costume or make one at home
- Only a few people go all out
- . . . like this



Photo: MatadorianGray, CC BY 3.0

After the age of 16

- Nobody goes trick-or-treating anymore
- Instead: Halloween parties
- Usually pretty cringe

The lazy costume

- Costumes get lazier with age
- Cat ears + black clothes = a cat
- A T-shirt + antennae = a bee





Left: Annie Pilon, CC BY 2.0. Right: a lazy bee next to a not-so-lazy lion, LBJ Library, public domain

Activity

Guess the costumes

What are the top 5 costumes in the US this year?

- For children
- For adults
- Bonus: for pets!



Photo: Petr Kratochvil, CC0

The answers: top costumes of 2026

	Children		Adults	
1	Spider-Man	4.6 million	Witch	4.8 million
2	Superhero	2.3 million	Vampire	4.2 million
3	Princess	2.2 million	Batman	2.0 million
4	Witch	1.6 million	Spider-Man	1.5 million
5	Ghost	1.6 million	Ghost	1.4 million

Pets: 1. Pumpkin 2. Hot dog 3. Ghost

Source: National Retail Federation, Halloween survey (September 2026).

And in Austria?



Sternsinger in Carinthia. Photo: Naturpuur, CC BY 4.0

Sternsinger (January): children in costume go door to door, sing, and collect money



Krampuslauf in Pörtschach. Photo: Johann Jaritz, CC BY-SA 3.0 AT

Krampus (December): scary costumes in the streets

Which is closest to American Halloween?

Happy Halloween!